

# The Wrong Train

She had taken the wrong train. By the time she realised, she had already learned something she needed to know.

CEFR Level B1

Book 4 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A train journey across northern England. An October afternoon.

Genre: Drama / Encounter

## Characters

- Clare — 46. HR director. Efficient, overcommitted, not used to being lost.
- Emmett — 68. Retired headteacher. Has been making the same journey for forty years.
- The train itself — important as a space where normal rules don't apply.

Clare had taken the 14:22 from Leeds. She had been so sure she had taken the 14:22 from Leeds that she had not checked the destination board before she boarded.

She had been answering emails while the train pulled out of the station.

It was only when the conductor — a young woman with a very particular expression that Clare recognised as professional patience — said 'Ticket and destination, please' that Clare looked up and saw the problem.

The conductor looked at her ticket. Then at Clare. Then at the ticket again.

'You want the other platform,' the conductor said.

Manchester.

The conductor had been helpful — she had explained the options with the practiced efficiency of someone who dealt with this several times a week.

Clare could get off at Harrogate, wait forty minutes, and take a train back to Leeds and then catch the 15:47 to Manchester. This would make her forty minutes late for her meeting.

Or she could stay on this train to York, and from York take a different connection that would also arrive in Manchester, also forty minutes late.

Either way, she was going to be late.

She called the meeting.

This was unusual — her phone was in her hand for most of her waking hours.

The man sitting across the table from her had been reading a book and had not appeared to notice her situation.

He was in his late sixties, with grey hair and the kind of unhurried quality that Clare associated with people who had retired. He was wearing a good tweed jacket.

He looked up from his book now, though whether he had heard the call or simply noticed that the phone was gone was unclear.

'Harrogate or York?' he said.

'York,' Clare said. She was not entirely sure why.

Emmett nodded. 'Better connection from York,' he said. 'And you have more time. Harrogate in forty minutes is tight.'

'Do you make this journey often?' 'I've been making this journey approximately every three weeks for forty years,' he said. 'I know every version of the connections.'

He went back to his book.

Clare looked out of the window. They were passing through countryside she didn't recognise — bare hills, the beginning of autumn.

She had a laptop in her bag. She did not take it out.

He showed her the cover — a history of the Yorkshire Dales, which was not the kind of book she had picked up since university.

'Are you local?' she asked.

'I was. I grew up in Skipton. I've lived in Leeds for the last thirty years — I moved for a job and never left.'

'Do you miss it? Skipton?'

Emmett considered this properly, which Clare noticed because she was not used to people considering questions properly.

'I don't think miss is right,' he said. 'I think I carry it. It comes with me. Is that the same thing?'

'No,' Clare said, after a moment. 'I don't think it is.'

She told him — the meeting in Manchester, which was with a board member she found difficult, about a restructuring she had been asked to lead that she was not certain was the right decision.

She had not intended to say this much. The train seemed to have a particular effect on the amount she said.

'Is the restructuring right or wrong?' Emmett asked.

'That depends on what question you're asking,' Clare said.

'It will reduce costs. Whether that's the same as being right is a different question.'

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Clare realises she has taken the wrong train and lost control of her day.

He looked at her. 'Do you think your board member knows that difference?'

'No,' she said. 'Which is part of the problem.'

He was a retired headteacher.

She asked which school. He told her — a comprehensive in Leeds that had been, when he arrived, in serious difficulty, and that had been, when he left, considerably better.

'What did you do differently?' she asked.

'I stopped trying to fix the school from the outside,' he said. 'I tried to understand it from the inside first. It took about two years to understand it properly. Everything I tried to fix before I understood it made things worse.'

Clare looked at the hills.

'How long have you been doing this restructuring?' he asked.

'About a year,' she said. 'Properly, about six months.'

'And have you understood what you're changing yet?'

from the outside dışarıdan properly gerçekten, düzgünce made things worse işleri daha kötü yaptı "Have you understood what you're changing yet?" She does not answer immediately.

She thought about the question for longer than she should have, given that they were on a train and she had only known this man for twenty minutes.

'Probably not,' she said. 'I understand the numbers. I understand the structure. I don't know if I understand the people well enough.'

'What would it take to understand the people?' 'Time I haven't got.'

'Why haven't you got it?' 'Because the timeline was set before I was involved. By the board member I find difficult.'

Emmett looked out of the window. 'That seems like the kind of problem where you either slow the process down or you accept that what you're doing is managing the numbers rather than making a good decision.'

'Those are the only two options,' she said. 'You're right.'

slow down yavaşlatmak accept that... kabul etmek She named the problem clearly. Those are the only two options. She knows which one she has been doing.

The train stopped at Harrogate.

Several people got off. A woman with a pushchair got on and settled with the particular focused efficiency of someone who had done this many times.

Neither Clare nor Emmett said anything while the train was in the station.

When it pulled out again, Emmett said: 'Did you take this job because you believed in it or because it was the next step?'

Clare thought about how to answer this honestly. She had been honest with him once already on this train, which was unusual.

'Both,' she said. 'When I took it, both. I'm less sure about both now.'

'What changed?' 'This restructuring. And a few other things that had been building for a while.'

She had not, until this train journey, said it out loud, even to herself.

The job was good. She was good at it. The organisation was decent and the people, on the whole, were not bad.

But there was a category of decision — the kind this restructuring represented — where she was increasingly being asked to implement things she didn't believe were right.

Not wrong, exactly. Just — not right.

She was an HR director, which meant that people understood her as a function rather than as a person. She had been allowing this for a long time.

'You've been doing this for a while,' Emmett said. It was not a question.

'Yes,' she said. 'Too long, I think.'

realised, one of the reasons she had kept talking.

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A conversation with Emmett turns a delay into an unexpected lesson.

He asked questions. Good ones — the kind that required her to say what she actually thought rather than what she was used to saying.

She had spent a year in this job having conversations where she said what was expected. The board member who found the numbers reassuring. The colleagues who needed to believe everything was under control.

This train had been moving for forty minutes and she had already said three things she had not known she thought.

'Do you teach negotiation?' she asked.

'I taught fifteen-year-olds,' he said. 'Same thing, different vocabulary.'

York station announced itself with its particular Victorian grandeur.

Clare had forty minutes before her connection.

Emmett was continuing — his train went all the way to York and then onward.

'I'm getting off here,' Clare said. 'Thank you. For the conversation.'

'You did most of the talking,' Emmett said.

'That was the conversation,' she said.

He laughed. 'It usually is, when it's useful.'

She stood, gathered her things, and then paused.

'The school,' she said. 'When you took two years to understand it — was the understanding worth the wait?'

'Yes,' he said. 'Always.'

She found a bench — which felt significant, though she couldn't have said why — and sat with a cup of tea and thought about the conversation.

She thought about the restructuring. About the board member. About the question she had not been asking — not whether the numbers worked, but whether she understood the people well enough to know what the numbers meant.

She had a meeting in two hours.



She opened her notebook — she kept one for proper thinking, not for actions — and began to write.

The meeting in Manchester was forty-two minutes late. Clare had used the extra time on the train from York to prepare differently from how she would normally have prepared.

She had not prepared talking points. She had prepared questions.

The board member — Richard, whom she had always found him more interested in agreement than in accuracy — seemed, for the first time, slightly uncertain.

He had expected talking points. She had arrived with questions about what he understood about the people whose jobs would change.

The meeting took two hours. At the end of it, the timeline had been extended by six weeks.

She had said, at the key moment in the meeting, something she had not planned to say.

Richard had presented the restructuring timeline as fixed — externally required, non-negotiable.

Clare had said: 'If we do this in this timeline, we'll be managing numbers, not making a good decision. I'd like six more weeks to understand the impact properly. If, after six weeks, the numbers still say go — we go.'

Richard had been quiet for a moment.

'That seems reasonable,' he had said, which was not something she had expected him to say.

'Thank you,' she had said. 'I think it will make the difference between a good outcome and a difficult one.'

On the train back to Leeds that evening, she took out her phone.

She had fourteen emails. She looked at them briefly, then put the phone back in her bag.

This was unusual enough that she noticed herself doing it. She took out her notebook instead.

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When she arrives, the journey has changed the way she sees her life.

She wrote: What I thought I was doing, and what I was actually doing.

Under these two headings, she wrote for forty minutes. When the train pulled into Leeds, she had not answered a single email.

She had answered, she thought, something more important.

Six weeks later, the restructuring proceeded — revised, with what Clare considered a clearer understanding of its human cost.

It was not perfect. These things rarely were.

But three roles that had been scheduled for elimination had been redesigned instead. Two teams that had been going to be merged had remained separate because the work they did, properly understood, was not interchangeable.

Richard had signed off on all of this.

He had also, in the final meeting, said something that Clare had found unexpectedly generous: 'You were right to ask for the time. This is a better version.'

'Thank you,' Clare had said. 'It had help.'

She took the 14:22 from Leeds several times after that, for reasons that were not connected to taking the wrong train. She had begun to prefer the journey — she had started keeping her laptop in her bag and using the train for the notebook.

She had told two colleagues about Emmett. One had said she was romanticising a chance meeting. The other had said: 'What was the name of the school?'

She didn't know. She had not asked.

She thought about trying to find out. She thought about writing to him.

Then she thought: the conversation was complete. Some conversations are complete when they end.

She looked at the hills and agreed with herself.

She had thought, over the six weeks, about what the wrong train had actually done.

It had not given her new information. She had known, somewhere, everything that she had told Emmett on the train.

What it had done was create a space — forty minutes in which she had no obligations and no audience and no expectations and no emails to answer — and in that space, she had heard herself think.

She was surrounded, in ordinary life, by people who needed things from her. The train had been a space where no one needed anything.

This, she thought, was rarer than it should have been.

She began to protect it.

She kept the notebook habit.

She took the 14:22 from Leeds whenever she needed to think — which, it turned out, was more often than she had realised.

She began to notice the landscape in a way she had not before: the particular way the light changed over the hills between Leeds and Harrogate, the brief view of the Wharfe valley near Knaresborough.

She did not miss Emmett. The conversation had been what it had been — a particular thing that had happened once and was finished.

But she thought about the man who had been making the same journey every three weeks for forty years, carrying Skipton inside him like a second city.

She thought: I should carry things better. And then she thought about what she was already carrying.

## Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story so the reading pages remain in a natural storybook format.

|                           |                         |
|---------------------------|-------------------------|
| 1. destination board      | varış panosu            |
| 2. boarded                | bindi                   |
| 3. professional patience  | mesleki sabır           |
| 4. conductor              | kondüktör               |
| 5. pulled out of          | ayrıldı                 |
| 6. the other platform     | diğer platform          |
| 7. practiced efficiency   | pratik verimlilik       |
| 8. options                | seçenekler              |
| 9. connection             | aktarma, bağlantı       |
| 10. either way            | her iki durumda da      |
| 11. catch the train       | treni yakalamak         |
| 12. dealt with            | ... ile başa çıkmak     |
| 13. unhurried             | aceleci olmayan         |
| 14. tweed jacket          | tüvit ceket             |
| 15. associated with       | ... ile ilişkilendirmek |
| 16. retired               | emekli                  |
| 17. waking hours          | uyanık olduğu saatler   |
| 18. unclear               | belirsiz                |
| 19. approximately         | yaklaşık olarak         |
| 20. tight                 | zaman acı               |
| 21. bare hills            | çıplak tepeler          |
| 22. connections           | aktarmalar              |
| 23. version of            | versiyonu               |
| 24. laptop                | dizüstü bilgisayar      |
| 25. Yorkshire Dales       | Yorkshire tepeleri      |
| 26. considered properly   | düzgünce düşündü        |
| 27. carry it              | onu taşıyor             |
| 28. comes with me         | benimle geliyor         |
| 29. local                 | yerli                   |
| 30. picked up             | almak, okumak           |
| 31. restructuring         | yeniden yapılanma       |
| 32. board member          | yönetim kurulu üyesi    |
| 33. reduce costs          | maliyetleri azaltmak    |
| 34. intended to say       | söylemeyi düşünmüştü    |
| 35. particular effect     | özel etki               |
| 36. uncertain             | emin olmayan            |
| 37. comprehensive         | devlet okulu            |
| 38. in serious difficulty | ciddi sorunlar içinde   |

|                             |                             |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 39. considerably better     | önemli ölçüde daha iyi      |
| 40. timeline                | zaman çizelgesi             |
| 41. set before              | önceden belirlendi          |
| 42. managing the numbers    | rakamları yönetmek          |
| 43. involved                | dahil oldu                  |
| 44. pushchair               | bebek arabası               |
| 45. settled                 | yerleşti                    |
| 46. next step               | sıradaki adım               |
| 47. building for a while    | bir süredir birikiyordu     |
| 48. pulled out              | ayrıldı                     |
| 49. honest with him once    | bir kez dürüst olmuştı      |
| 50. implement               | uygulamak                   |
| 51. category                | kategori                    |
| 52. function (not a person) | işlev (insan değil)         |
| 53. decent                  | dürüst, iyi                 |
| 54. increasingly            | giderek artan               |
| 55. not wrong, exactly      | tam olarak yanlış değil     |
| 56. negotiation             | müzakere, anlaşma           |
| 57. reassuring              | güven verici                |
| 58. required her to say     | söylemesini gerektirdi      |
| 59. expected                | beklenen                    |
| 60. under control           | kontrol altında             |
| 61. vocabulary              | kelime dağarcığı            |
| 62. Victorian grandeur      | Viktorya dönemi görkemi     |
| 63. onward                  | daha öteye                  |
| 64. gathered her things     | eşyalarını topladı          |
| 65. paused                  | duraksadı                   |
| 66. was worth the wait      | beklemeye değerdi           |
| 67. most of the talking     | konuşmaların büyük bölümü   |
| 68. felt significant        | anlamli hissettirdi         |
| 69. proper thinking         | gerçek düşünme              |
| 70. took out                | çıkardı                     |
| 71. began to write          | yazmaya başladı             |
| 72. couldn't have said why  | neden olduğunu söyleyemezdi |
| 73. actions                 | eylemler                    |
| 74. talking points          | konuşma noktaları           |
| 75. accuracy                | doğruluk                    |
| 76. timeline extended       | zaman çizelgesi uzatıldı    |

|                                     |                             |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 77. agreement                       | anlaşma                     |
| 78. prepared questions              | sorular hazırladı           |
| 79. non-negotiable                  | pazarlık konusu olmayan     |
| 80. impact                          | etki                        |
| 81. externally required             | dışarıdan zorunlu kılınan   |
| 82. outcome                         | sonuç                       |
| 83. planned to say                  | söylemeyi planlamıştı       |
| 84. reasonable                      | makul                       |
| 85. headings                        | başlıklar                   |
| 86. briefly                         | kısaca                      |
| 87. noticed herself                 | kendini fark etti           |
| 88. instead                         | yerine                      |
| 89. pulled into                     | istasyona girdi             |
| 90. what I was actually doing       | gerçekte ne yaptığım        |
| 91. proceeded                       | devam etti                  |
| 92. elimination                     | çıkarma, budama             |
| 93. redesigned                      | yeniden tasarlandı          |
| 94. interchangeable                 | birbirinin yerine geçebilir |
| 95. signed off on                   | onayladı                    |
| 96. unexpectedly generous           | beklenmedik şekilde cömert  |
| 97. romanticising                   | romantikleştirmek           |
| 98. chance meeting                  | tesadüfi buluşma            |
| 99. complete                        | tamamlanmış                 |
| 100. prefer the journey             | yolculuğu tercih etmek      |
| 101. agreed with herself            | kendisiyle hemfikir oldu    |
| 102. connected to                   | ... ile bağlantılı          |
| 103. obligations                    | yükümlülükler               |
| 104. audience                       | izleyici, dinleyici         |
| 105. surrounded by                  | ... ile çevrelenmiş         |
| 106. protect it                     | korumak                     |
| 107. rarer than it should have been | olması gerekenden nadir     |
| 108. heard herself think            | kendini düşünürken duydu    |
| 109. landscape                      | manzara, coğrafya           |
| 110. brief view                     | kısa bir bakış              |
| 111. Wharfe valley                  | Wharfe vadisi               |
| 112. carrying                       | taşımak                     |
| 113. already carrying               | zaten taşıdığı              |
| 114. second city                    | ikinci şehir                |

## After-Reading Activities

### 1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase

Meaning

**1. destination board**

**A. kondüktör**

**2. conductor**

**B. varış panosu**

**3. comprehensive**

**C. devlet okulu**

4. non-negotiable

D. pazarlık konusu olmayan

5. interchangeable

E. birbirinin yerine geçebilir

6. obligations

F. yükümlülükler

7. romanticise

G. romantikleştirmek

8. landscape

H. manzara, coğrafya

### 2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

questions — numbers — complete — carrying — wrong —  
understanding

**1. Clare took the \_\_\_\_\_ train because she hadn't looked at the destination board.**

**2. Emmett said his school improved when he stopped trying to fix it before he had understood it — the \_\_\_\_\_ came first.**

**3. Clare said if they proceeded too soon, they would be managing \_\_\_\_\_, not making a good decision.**



4. She prepared \_\_\_\_\_ for the Manchester meeting instead of talking points.
5. She thought: some conversations are \_\_\_\_\_ when they end.
6. She thought about Emmett \_\_\_\_\_ Skipton inside him like a second city.

### **3. Comprehension Questions**

**True or False? Write T or F.**

**1. Clare realises her mistake before the train leaves the station. \_\_\_\_**

**2. Emmett is a retired lawyer. \_\_\_\_**

**3. Clare is confident that the restructuring she is leading is the right decision. \_\_\_\_**

4. Clare uses her laptop during the journey. \_\_\_\_
5. The meeting in Manchester results in a six-week extension to the timeline. \_\_\_\_
6. Clare tries to contact Emmett after the journey. \_\_\_\_

### **Short Answer Questions**

7. What is the choice Clare has to make after boarding the wrong train?
8. How does Emmett describe his relationship with Skipton?
9. What parallel does Emmett's experience at the school have with Clare's situation?
10. What has been 'building' in Clare's relationship with her job?
11. What does Clare do differently to prepare for the Manchester meeting?
12. What does Clare say in the meeting that surprises Richard?
13. What concrete changes result from the extended timeline?
14. What does Clare mean when she says the train 'created a space'?
15. Why does Clare decide not to try to contact Emmett?

## Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. wrong 2. understanding 3. numbers 4. questions  
5. complete 6.  
carrying

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. F 5. T 6. F

7. She can get off at Harrogate and return to Leeds (forty minutes late)  
or continue to

York and connect from there (also forty minutes late).

8. He doesn't 'miss' it — he carries it. It comes with him. That's  
different from missing  
something.

9. He tried to fix the school before he understood it and made things  
worse — Clare is  
doing the same with the restructuring.

10. She is increasingly being asked to implement decisions she doesn't  
believe are  
right — managing numbers rather than making good decisions. She  
has been allowing  
this for too long.

11. She prepares questions rather than talking points — questions  
about what Richard  
understands about the people whose jobs will change.

12. She says if they proceed on the current timeline, they will be  
managing numbers,  
not making a good decision — she asks for six more weeks.

13. Three roles were redesigned rather than eliminated; two teams  
that were going to  
be merged remained separate because their work was not  
interchangeable.

14. A space with no obligations, no audience, no expectations — where  
she had no  
emails to answer and could hear herself think.

15. Because the conversation was complete when it ended — some  
conversations  
don't need continuation.